

Associate Dean,
Undergraduate
Faculty of Science
University of Alberta

July 12, 2026

Dear Associate Dean,

My name is Shafin Ahmed and my student ID is 1835948. I'm going to be in my 4th year at the Faculty of Science in the department of Computing Science. I received a **may not continue** letter on June 8, 2026 that requires me to transfer away from my program due to not meeting the continuation requirement. I submitted an appeal to that letter and I received another letter on June 30, 2026 to inform me that my appeal is not granted. The letter stated that I'm allowed to appeal the decision to the Associate Dean, Undergraduate of the Faculty of Science. I would like to appeal that decision.

Firstly, I would like to take full responsibility for my actions that led to my current academic standing. I would like to take this chance to explain the circumstances that led to the current academic standing. For the past 2 years, I have been dealing with both emotional and mental stressors that have affected a major portion of my daily life. As an international student, I came to Canada at the age of 18 by myself without knowing any friends or family prior to arriving. I wanted to take this risk in order to better myself and learn more about life. However, things didn't go as expected. I felt that I've lived more in the past 3 years than the 18 years before that. I had experienced both good and bad things by living independently and far away from home. However, the bad things that I've experienced so far have outweighed the good. In the past 2 years, what I have been constantly experiencing so far can be described as extreme loneliness. As someone coming from a very family orientated home, being far away from my family for many months had a major impact on my mental health. I struggled having to only be able to see my family faces on a video call. Additionally, being far away from all the friends I have made prior to coming to Canada have contributed significantly to my loneliness. I realized that making and maintaining friends in university and as an adult in general is a much more difficult task than I thought it would be. While I knew that this would be a problem since my first year, I really tried to participate in some campus clubs and make connections with groupmates or classmates from my classes and roommates in the residence. Nonetheless, It was very difficult to maintain any long-term connections with the people that I had met due to their own personal circumstances and my workload. As a result, I had spent most of my time alone without any close relationships which made my loneliness significantly worse.

I did try to alleviate some of the loneliness by finding hobbies that I could do by myself and utilizing the mental health services available on campus. I started going to the gym and trying new cooking recipes and I had found that these activities did help me forget my loneliness for a while. However, loneliness in my experience was like a shadow that kept clinging on to me. I would suddenly go through periods where I would feel very depressed and a simple task like

waking up was a struggle. Also, coming from a place where mental health is still a stigma. I couldn't really keep up with the social support services available on campus because I sometimes felt uncomfortable opening up about my deep personal issues. Looking back, I think that this was a major mistake as I should've looked at it in a different way where the people at those social support services are there for the sole purpose of helping me. Receiving the first may not continue letter was really a wake up call for me that I needed to make changes and get the proper help. I did come up with the changes I needed to make and tried to implement those changes, unfortunately things didn't always go as planned. While I did learn and start new hobbies that had sometimes helped me with my loneliness. I kept going through a pattern where I would switch between periods of my wellbeing that was just good enough to keep me going through life and then feeling extremely depressed and lonely that basic life tasks felt like the hardest tasks in the world. This was the main thing pulling me back from my desired academic standing.

Although, things didn't go as perfect as I had wanted. I did learn a lot and gain new experience about what worked for me and what didn't. I noticed that trying new activities or hobbies that I could do by myself was the thing that worked the best because it allowed me to relax and have fun without needing the company of others. For example, going to the gym is still something that I do regularly to this day. Also, now that I'm back home. While I could spend time with friends and family, I've always taken some time where I spend it by doing activities by myself that I found enjoyable such as going to movies, trying out a new restaurant and going to a soccer match. Throughout this predicament, I realized that the best way to alleviate the loneliness and depression that I felt was to feel comfortable with doing things that I found enjoyable and be able to enjoy my own company. Additionally, I will also change the way I look at seeking help by letting go of the stigma that I will get judged for my personal emotional and mental issues. I intend to be more consistent with seeking professional help from services available from the mental health supports for students and also informal help from my friends and family as I've already opened up to them about the personal things I had experienced since moving to Canada.

Finally, I'm grateful to the department and faculty for the chances that I've been given and I'm aware that I've been given plenty. Despite the hardship that I had faced, I had learned a lot about things within myself and about navigating through life and a part of me is grateful for that. Even though things had not turned out the way that I had wanted. I'm still determined to make a point and prove that I'm able to make changes and improve myself. Thus, I would like to seek the opportunity to remain in my current program. I'm aware that it might be hard to give me the trust that I'm capable of making changes and improving my academic performances. However, I'm asking that I'm given just one semester only to show that I can meet the necessary requirements. If I still failed to meet the requirement in that semester then I will accept the necessary consequences. I will also accept any additional conditions that you see fits. However, I request that I'm given a chance to prove that I can change myself and my academic performance. I know within myself that my issue isn't an academic issue but rather a situational issue that I had not foreseen and I believe that I can turn around both my personal life and academic performance.

Thank you in advance for your consideration in this issue. I can be contacted by email at shafin3@ualberta.ca. Please do not hesitate to contact me if you need further details.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Shafin'.

Shafin Ahmed
1835948
shafin3@ualberta.ca